

A Short Note on MEGA IV/32: Catalog of the Partially Reconstructed Personal Libraries of Marx and Engels

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It has been reported that when Frederick Engels died in 1895 the combined library of Marx and Engels contained some 2100 titles in 3200 volumes (the two libraries had been joined together after the death of Karl Marx in 1883). Some 1450 titles (2100 volumes) of these have been identified and located so far. In 1999 the Akademie Verlag of Berlin brought out a catalog of these titles, prepared at the Berlin-Brandenburg Academy of Sciences by a team of German and Russian scholars. It is a *Vorauspublication* (prepublication) of the MEGA (*Marx-Engels-Gesamtausgabe* [Complete Works of Marx and Engels]), section IV, volume 32. It contains the result of some seventy-five years of search and research. The work began in the middle of 1920s in the archives of the Social Democratic Party of Germany at Berlin, continued in the Marx-Engels Archives at Moscow and Berlin, and was completed at the Berlin-Brandenburg Academy of Sciences under the auspices of the International Marx-Engels Foundation located at the International Institute of Social History of Amsterdam.

This library contains works on economy, history of economics, philosophy, social and natural sciences, general history, history of socialism and of the workers' movement, encyclopedias, dictionaries, textbooks of different languages, memoirs, biographies, treatises on literary studies, many classics from the field of *belles-lettres* and, publications on military science. The books are in ten languages. A third of them are in German, a quarter each are in English and French. Some sixteen percent are in the Cyrillic scripts of the Slavic languages.

The English manufacturer, social reformer, and early socialist Robert Owen tops the list of authors with sixteen single titles. He is followed by Marx's mentor in the circle of Left Hegelians, the radical theologian and critic of religion Bruno Bauer, with fifteen titles. The Russian scholar of public law and historian of comparative law, a friend of Marx and Engels in the realm of scientific research, Maksim Maksimovich Kovalevskij; and a representative of the Russian revolutionary movement abroad, Pyotr Lavrovich Lavrov occupy the next position, with fourteen titles to the credit of each. They are followed by the Russian revolutionary and political adversary of Marx and Engels, Mikhail Aleksandrovich Bakunin, with twelve titles. The next slot goes to one of the most important authors for the young Marx, Pierre-Joseph Proudhon, with eleven titles. Marx broke off with Proudhon intellectually in 1847 with the polemical treatise *The Poverty of Philosophy*.

Marx's political colleague and rival Ferdinand Lassalle, the Italian economist and publicist Achille Loria, and the Turkophil Tory David Urquhart come next with ten titles each. There are eight titles by the British agronomist William Marshall and, seven titles each by Edward Bibbins Aveling, Ernest Belfort Bax, Nikolai Gavrilovich Chernyshavskii, Gabriel Deville, and Eugene Dühring. Next come Marx's long-standing Russian correspondent and translator of *Capital*, Nikolai Francevich Daniel'son; a follower of Lassalle, Bernhard Becker; and Marx and Engels's personal friend and professor of chemistry at Manchester, Carl Schorlemmer, with six titles each. The library also contains the intellectual point of departure of the young Marx – the works of Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel.

It is well known that in London Marx used the library of the British Museum. Perhaps this explains the absence of Darwin or Senior or Macaulay in his personal collection. For them one will have to look into the voluminous excerpts-filled notebooks of Marx and Engels, which are being published in the remaining thirty-one volumes of Section IV of the MEGA (of these, so far, nine volumes have been published). Some eight hundred volumes of their personal library contain forty thousand pages, where the "sites of readings" are underscored and/or provided with marginal notes.

The journey undertaken by the personal library of Marx and Engels is itself an interesting part of the political history of nineteenth-and twentieth-century Europe. Built out of the ground stock of their family libraries, it increased through decades-long acquisitions and gifts and, at times, decreased owing to reasons beyond the control of Marx or Engels.

The first documented reference to Marx's personal library dates back to May 1849. At that time police persecution forced Marx to part company with some five hundred titles in his personal collection. He handed over the books to his friend Dr. Roland Daniels of Cologne. The books were kept in the cellars of the warehouse of the wine-merchant brothers of Dr. Daniels. The collection arrived in London in 1860, but stolen in transit were the whole of Fourier, Goethe, Herder, Voltaire, and books by many eighteenth-century economists, as well as many volumes of the Greek classics. After Marx's death, his library was joined with that of Engels, who had by then acquired a considerable number of books on military science. On Engels's death, all the books went to Bebel and Singer. The books were put in twenty-seven boxes and sent to the office of the Social Democratic Party of Germany (SPD) in Berlin, where these became part of the SPD library. The people administering the library were careless about this legacy. Many comments on the margins were lost through the bookbinders' cut. When the Nazis came to power, the books were scattered. Books in the secret Prussian State Archives at Berlin-Dahlem were thrown out. Soon the universities followed suit. At the conclusion of the Second World War, the "Trophy Commission" of the victorious Red Army, spread over more than twenty garrisons, further scattered the remaining titles. Beginning with the 1950s, a systematic search was initiated in the German Democratic Republic for the titles *ex libris* Marx and Engels. The present catalog is the result of this and similar efforts up to 1999.

This catalog is more than a mere bibliographic survey. The catalog permits one to gain an insight into the conditions in which Marx and Engels carried out their scientific, political, and publishing activities on questions that lay at the basis of their research. If their path of investigation and its historical phases are not fully taken into account, then Marx-Engels studies at times passes over into the realm of speculation and wishful constructs. Such, for instance, is the case with the alleged three sources and three component parts of Marx's legacy. It is widely held (at least, since Lenin's 1913 article on the theme), that Marxism grew out of classical German philosophy from Kant to Hegel, the utopian socialism of Owen, Fourier, and Saint-Simon, and the English political economy of Smith, Ricardo, and Mill; and, that Marx and Engels set the idealist dialectic of the first on its feet, transformed the utopia of the second into a science, and overcame the limits of the bourgeois perception of the third. Marx/Engels studies have superseded and continue to overcome this partial and hence incorrect understanding.

Marx and Engels lived and worked in many countries of Europe – in Germany, France, Belgium, and England. The international perspective that they acquired as early as the 1840s influenced their work. This is especially true of Marx. It appears from the various volumes of the *MEGA* and from a survey of the still unpublished notes and manuscripts preserved at Amsterdam and Moscow that Marx not only studied a large number of disciplines – law, philosophy, history, political economy, technology, agriculture, chemistry, physics, geology, mathematics, physiology, ethnology, and others – but also studied the history and conditions of a large number of countries and regions – among them Germany, France, England, Ireland, Scandinavia, Poland, Russia, the Balkans, Italy, Spain, the United States, Latin America, Algeria, India, and China. The legacy of Marx is founded upon and consists of these studies. Knowledge of the scope of these horizons of encyclopedic depth is a necessity for the contemporary students of Marx and fighters for socialism.

The sources for this note are a press release entitled "Akademie Verlag Veröffentlicht Verzeichnis der Bibliotheken von Marx und Engels" and an article by Jens Bisky, "Unvollständiges Verzeichnis der Arbeitsmittel Zweikampf mit Stoff und Verfasser: Ein Verzeichnis der Privatbibliotheken von Karl Marx und Friedrich Engels," *Berliner Zeitung* 7 January 2000. Both were sent to me by Prof. Manfred Neuhaus of the Berlin-Brandenburg Academy of Sciences with a letter dated 20 January 2000.

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